

Section A- Context

If you observe any college classroom today, almost every student is digitally active. Some are updating their LinkedIn, others are pushing code to GitHub, and a few are creating a Canva poster for a club event or for their own use. From the outside, this seems like digital fluency. It seems like a generation that grew up with technology and knows how to use it well.

But here's a question worth asking: does knowing how to use something mean you understand it?

Think about how most students learn to use digital tools. No one explained copyright law before they started downloading images from Google for their presentations. Nobody walked them through data privacy policies before they signed up for a new platform. They simply opened the app, figured it out as they went, and got things done. The tools are designed to allow this drag-and-drop interfaces, ready-made templates, AI-generated suggestions. They don't need to understand how something works to operate it. That's precisely the problem.

The consequences of this gap are more serious than just a missed situation. When students don't understand copyright, they risk plagiarizing without realizing it. When they don't question visual framing, they may unintentionally share misleading information. When they treat every informal GIF or meme as appropriate in any context, they lose awareness of their audience. This skill is very important in professional settings. The bigger concern is that education systems are increasingly focusing on the output how polished a presentation looks—without considering the process behind it.

Digital literacy isn't just about knowing which buttons to click. It involves understanding why you are clicking them, what the content means, and who it might affect. Tools like Canva and Miro can be genuinely useful when used thoughtfully. However, this case study shows that being familiar with a tool and being fluent in its purpose are two very different things. Closing that gap should be a priority in modern digital education.

We live in a time when making a presentation, designing a poster, or putting together a project report requires almost no effort. You can open Canva, choose a template, drag in some images, write a few lines, and finish in under an hour. It looks good. It feels productive. But somewhere in that process, we skip something important: the thinking part. This case study explores how the convenience of modern digital tools is slowly replacing the critical thinking that education should develop. It looks at real patterns of student behavior, examines why this happens, and explains why it is a problem that extends beyond a few missed citations or a poorly chosen GIF.

Before diving into the problem, it's important to understand what these tools are meant to do. Platforms like Canva, Adobe Express, Google Slides, and even AI writing assistants are based on one main idea: reduce friction. The fewer steps a user has to take, the better the product works in the market.

This means

You don't need to know design principles; the template handles it.

You don't need to understand layout or typography; the tool auto-suggests it.

You don't need to evaluate sources; you just paste content in.

For students, this feels like freedom. In reality, it quietly removes the thinking process itself. Overtime, students become consumers of digital convenience rather than critical thinkers.

Why Students Stop Questioning

Students abandon questioning for multiple causes.

AI can done work fast – by help of the AI students can finish their assignment and homework more quickly and easily without doing any hardwork.

The output looks finished- Traditional methods handwritten notes, hand-drawn diagrams feel incomplete until they are worked on. A Canva presentation looks finished from the first draft. That feeling of completion reduces the motivation to revise or question. And make easy for student to do the work.

So student choose easy and fast work rather than questioning and doing hardwork for that work.

Over time, the pattern described above produces a specific kind of student one who is highly skilled at operating tools but genuinely underprepared to think independently. They can produce outputs that look like critical work without any of the underlying reasoning.

Convenience is not the enemy. Canva, Prezi, Miro, and similar tools are genuinely powerful when used thoughtfully. The problem is not the tools themselves — it is the absence of guidance on how to use them critically.

These are not technical questions. They are thinking questions. And no template, however beautiful, can answer them for you. The most important digital skill a student can develop is not knowing which tool to open it is knowing when to pause before clicking.

Section B - Digital Identity & Ethics

Before getting into the arguments, let me be clear about where I stand: building a digital presence does benefit students - yes it benefit but only when they understand what they're actually building. Right now, most students don't know . And because of that, they're not building opportunities or carriers -they're building a record of their unawareness .

Does digital platforms create equal opportunities?

One of the strongest arguments people make in favor of platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub is the equal opportunity argument. The idea is simple: it doesn't matter what college you're from, what city you grew up in, or what connections your family has -if you put your work online, anyone can see it. A student from a small town with real skills can reach the same recruiters as someone from a top-tier institution. That sounds genuinely fair.

And honestly, in theory, it is. I believe that part is real. There are actual stories of people getting noticed on GitHub or LinkedIn purely based on work they posted, with no pedigree behind them. The platform itself doesn't care where you studied.

Like my brother friend rohit he was from a tier 3 collage and yet he was able to get placed in a top company with the help of his github profile. The recruiter was drawn to his standout GitHub profile featuring a Node.js REST API, React weather app, and e-commerce project-complete with clear commits, a debugging blog post. So he get the proper chance to give the interview of that company.

But here's where the theory breaks down in practice.

The equal opportunity only exists if what people are posting actually reflects their real skills. And as Part 2 of this case study shows pretty clearly, that's what's happening. When Arjun lists skills on LinkedIn that he barely explored, and another student lists the same skills with genuine depth — both profiles look identical to a recruiter scrolling quickly. The platform has made them look equal, but they're not. So the "equal opportunity" ends up being equal opportunity to perform, not equal opportunity to compete on actual merit.

What this creates is a strange situation where the platform that was supposed to remove barriers actually creates a new one: the ability to present yourself well becomes more important than the skills themselves. Now student more focus on presenting themselves more creative and showing that they know everythings. Rather than focusing on learning new skills.

So yes, equal opportunity exists in theory. In practice, it's more complicated.

Performance over authenticity

This is the part that I think is most honest and most uncomfortable to admit.

When you're on LinkedIn or github, you're not really showing who you are. You're showing who you want people to think you are. It's the platform encourages. "Optimize your profile", "Use keywords recruiters search for." "Show your best work." Every piece of advice that everyone give about LinkedIn is about performance, presentation, and visibility.

The result is exactly what happened with Arjun. He wasn't some unusual case of a dishonest student. He was doing exactly what everyone around him was doing — presenting himself in the best possible way, filling in profile fields, uploading whatever work he had, listing whatever skills seemed relevant. And yes everyone does that.

Infact When I started the linkedin I also filled that I know python but in reality I just learned python for only 10 days. So yes it is a usually practice on these platforms to look presentative and visible.

And the truth is that this becomes a habit. When you spend enough time managing your digital image, you start thinking about your actual learning in terms of how it will look on your profile rather than what it actually means for your knowledge. You take the certification not because you want to understand the subject but because it looks good on your LinkedIn profile. Just to make your profile attractive you take many certificate that are not even needed.

So yes I agree with this argument that online platforms encourage performance over authenticity, where students focus more on visibility than actual competence.

The issue of misrepresentation

Exaggerating skills or presenting incomplete work as is ethically wrong, in my opinion.

Here's why I still think it's ethically wrong, even if it's common. When everyone exaggerates slightly, the baseline shifts. Now genuinely qualified students need to exaggerate more to stand out. It becomes a race toward misrepresentation where no one wins except the people who are best at performing confidence and don't have skills. Students who are genuinely skilled but honest about their knowledge and their work get left behind because their profiles look "humble" in an environment that rewards bold claims.

More importantly, the misrepresentation doesn't just affect the student. It affects recruiters who make decisions based on false information. It affects companies that hire people for skills they don't actually have. And it affects the student themselves when they get into a role or a project that requires the skills they claimed — and they can't deliver. Then they face the problem ther. And maybe lost their job as they do not have the skill required to do the job.

Arjun's GitHub showing incomplete, copied code isn't just an exaggeration. It's a representation of work that isn't his, presented as if it is. And this is not correct in my point of view. You should upload based on your knowledge only.

The concept of digital permanence

Digital permanence refers to the idea that online posts, photos, and content often persist indefinitely, even if deleted, due to screenshots, archives, or data retention by platforms.

In a classroom, mistakes are temporary. You give a wrong answer, the moment passes, you learn and move on. Nobody is keeping a permanent record of every wrong thing you said or done during a lecture two years ago. But online, it works completely differently. Everything is searchable. Everything stays.

In my opinion students should not be held accountable for everything they post, if they lacked awareness at the time because they have not idea at that time what they are doing.

Arjun's poorly written code from second year is still on GitHub. His incorrect Stack Overflow answers are still there. His LinkedIn from when he barely knew the tools he listed is still visible. Three years from now, when he's actually skilled and genuinely qualified, a recruiter who does a deep check won't see a growth story — they'll see inconsistency.

In 2017, a Pennsylvania cheerleader (B.L.) posted Snapchat images off-campus cursing the school and team after being benched. The school suspended her, citing team morale disruption. The U.S. Supreme Court ruled 8-1 in her favor: Schools can't punish off-campus speech without substantial interference, protecting her First Amendment rights despite the negativity. This case shows accountability limits—context mattered over permanence.

Students cannot be held to a standard they were never taught. If no one explains digital permanence before encouraging student to build a digital presence, then the failure isn't purely individual. The education system, the platforms, and the culture around digital participation share responsibility for the fact that students are building permanent records without being warned about what that means.

This is what makes it a systemic problem and not just Arjun's personal mistake.

After thinking through this, I went back and looked at my own GitHub and LinkedIn with completely different eyes.

There were things I had posted that I had completely forgotten about - an early project that was half finished, a skill I had listed that I barely understood at the time, an answer I had given somewhere online that I now know was partially wrong.

Section C - Collaboration vs. Misuse

Digital collaboration, when used without accountability, can produce strong outputs without ensuring meaningful learning

This statement touches on a fundamental modern education and professional environments - the gap between performance and understanding.

Learning, at its core, requires hardwork, ownership. When digital collaboration removes friction entirely, it also removes the cognitive effort that need deeper understanding. A student who submits an AI-generated assignment may receive an "A" but he did not have enough knowledge. A team member who copies a colleague's solution may perform well today but remain unable to debug it tomorrow.

Are These Tools Actually Making Us Learn?

Let me start with my own example-

I have been part of at least two or three group assignments in my first semester of college where the exact same thing happened that happened with Arjun's group. My friend does most of the work, someone else formats it nicely, other group member adds a few slides the night before, and everyone's name goes on the title page. We all get marks. Nobody questions it. We move on. But in actual we did not learn much from it. We did not understand the core concept of doing that assignment.

And I never really stopped to think about whether that was a problem until now.

The question this section is asking is really a good one - are platforms like Google Docs and shared workspaces actually making us learn better, or are they just making it easier to finish assignments without learning anything?

My honest answer after thinking about it is -both, depending entirely on how the student uses them. But the way most college student actually use them, the second thing happens far more often than the first. Because the student never want to do the hardwork, research the topic and give time to the topic. They just want to finished the assignment and waste their free time. So yes if we use these tools efficiently and only for learning purpose they can help us in a good way and enhance our knowledge. Its enhance our learning and make our our easier if we use our thinking and these tools in equal amount.

What These Platforms Were Supposed To Do

In my opinion, these tools themselves are not the problem. Google Docs is genuinely powerful. Multiple people can work on the same document simultaneously, leave comments, suggest edits, track changes. In theory this should mean more discussion, more collaboration, more engagement with the actual content. Its can helps us in many ways.

And sometimes that does happen. I have been in a group in my English course where we genuinely debated over what to write, where someone left a comment disagreeing with a point and we had a real back and forth about it in the document. That felt like actual learning. Everyone in that group could explain the final output because everyone had fought over what it should say. And on that day we really understand why assignment are given in groups.

What usually happens instead is much simpler. I tell you what happen in my group. Our group makes a quick plan on WhatsApp - I do slides 1 to 4, rohan do 5 to 8, mohit do 9 to 12. Everyone works in their own section separately. Nobody reads anyone else's part until the night before submission. The document gets assembled, not collaborated on.

So yes this happen in most of the cases.

Where should the boundary be drawn between collaboration and academic dishonesty?

Collaboration is encouraged when students work together to understand concepts, when they truly learn something and get benefits from it while academic dishonesty occurs when students work together to produce a final assignment that is intended to be an individual effort And did not get benefit or knowledge from it. Just simply make the assignment using the tools and not understanding anything from it.

So until you are doing the work with your thinking and using your brain to do the assignment and taking the helps from the tools to make your project look good or taking the idea , seeing the sample. Its is good. But there should be boundary not to entirely depend on the tools to do the assignment and not using your brain to the the works just simply copy pasting the exeat line by line from the tools.

Action	Collaboration	Academic Dishonesty
Assignments	Discussing general approaches to a problem with each other.	Sharing written answers, files, or code to be copied with each other
Writing	Writing by taking help with each other. And come up with your idea	Rewriting a partner's draft and do some small changes and submit it.
Studying	Explaining concepts in your own words.	Just copy from other notes
Group Work	Contributing equally to a team project.	Allowing one person to do all the work while others sign their name

Digital environments often reduce visibility of individual effort. Does this make ethical behavior harder to enforce?

Yes, in my opinion its is true. In a physical group assignment - if you're sitting together in a room working on a project- it's obvious who's contributing and who isn't. Social pressure, eye contact all push people to participate. You can't just sit silently in a room full of people who are working . It feels bad. People notice. And you participate in the discussion.

Online, none of that exists.

You can be "active" on a shared document by making small changes. You can be listed as a contributor because you opened the file twice. The platform records your presence, not your effort and hardwork. And because everything looks like participation from the outside, it's very difficult for anyone - including the professor -to see what actually happened and who does all the work and who did not.

This doesn't just make ethical behavior harder to enforce from the outside. It makes it harder to maintain from the inside too. When there's no social pressure, no visibility- the people do less hardwork. Not because students are lazy or dishonest by nature, but because the environment removes the natural friction that usually pushes people to contribute and support their team member.

so yes, I think digital collaboration environments do make unethical behavior easier - not by encouraging it, but by reducing the visibility that usually discourages the student.

Ethics *Harder* to Enforce-

Dimension	Physical Environment	Digital Environment
Visibility	High	Low
Accountability	Observable	Less observable
Social pressure to behave	Present	weak
Enforcement	Supervision	Systems & trust

Digital collaboration improves learning significantly and should not be restricted.

Okay, the assignment specifically asks me to build the strongest possible argument that digital collaboration genuinely improves learning and should not be restricted. So let me actually try to answer this question properly-

Yes collaboration improves learning significantly. Just the main thing is that we use it only to take ideas, improves our knowledge and ask question about it. Not just simply copy its from one place or other.

Digital collaboration tools give students access to something that physical group work never could genuine participation. Not everyone thinks best in real time. Some people process slowly, need time to research before they contribute, do their best work at 2 am. Shared platforms allow these students to participate fully without being limited by scheduling, or the social dynamics of a physical room. They can freely add their point of view when they get the idea or points.

Beyond that, working on a shared document teaches skills that are directly relevant to professional life and help them to achieve their dreams in their life. Every real workplace uses collaborative tools. Learning to give and receive feedback through comments , discussion and to manage version control, to coordinate work across people — these are not just academic exercises. They are the actual skills modern jobs require. That should be present in your resume while applying for a job.

Digital collaboration tools boost student confident and academic performance through interactive features like shared documents and real-time discussions. Studies show they enhance critical thinking, questioning the things, knowledge retention, and skills like teamwork, participating in the discussions, making decision making learning more effective than traditional methods alone.

Key Benefits

- Tools increase active participation, with higher motivation and personalized feedback.
- They promote inclusive environments, helping learners access resources at their own pace and take their time.

- Outcomes include better test scores and project quality, preparing students for real-world collaboration.

Section D: Cyber Awareness and Responsibility

Why do cyber crimes such as phishing, fraud, and identity theft continue to succeed despite widespread awareness campaigns?

Okay I'll be honest — when I first read about Arjun clicking on that fake internship link, my first reaction was "how did he not see that coming." And then I kept reading. And then I felt a little uncomfortable because I realized I have done almost the exact same thing before.

Yes it is true when I entered in the collage i also thought to do the internship in my first semester only. So one day on my collage mail id one internship mail has come. I thought it is from collage side. So I register and fill the form that was given.

Then after 10-15 days a phone call came . they first tell about their course and said many people gets benefit from it. Like to convince me he done a lot of praise of the course. And when I ask how to join it. He said just you have to pay 6000 rupees to get enrolled in the course and when the course end you definitely get internship. So luckily I did not get enrolled in the course. But my friend did and he just lost 6000 rupees he never get enrolled in any course.

And that's exactly what Arjun did. And that's exactly why cyber crimes keep working despite everyone technically knowing about them.

They just fall for it in order to get a bright future or trap in their false hopes.

Every college has done it. A one hour session on cyber safety. A poster in the computer lab saying "don't share your passwords." An email from the IT department with a list of tips. Maybe a short video during orientation week. Yes this is true.

And then everyone forgets about it and moves on. And not think about it.

The problem with awareness campaigns is that they treat cyber safety like a knowledge problem. Like if we just tell people what phishing is, they'll never fall for it. But Arjun knew what phishing was. He had literally been taught about it. And in the moment - when there was a real email, a real logo, a real sense of urgency about an internship he actually wanted -that classroom knowledge completely disappeared. Student forgets everything and just wanted that opportunity.

Because cyber crimes don't attack your knowledge. They attack your emotions. And you fall for it. That's why these crimes keep succeeding. Not because people are stupid or careless. But because the attacks bypass the rational thinking.

To what extent is the user responsible for protecting themselves, and to what extent should platforms or institutions be held accountable?

The easy answer is - the user should have been more careful and think before clicking a link. Arjun knew better. He should have checked the sender address. He should have gone to the official website instead of clicking the link. He should have think again before filling in that form.

All of that is true. And I do think individual responsibility matters here more. You can't outsource your own digital safety entirely to someone else. You should be more careful in such case and do not rush thing.

But then I also think putting all the blame on the user is a convenient way for platforms and institutions to avoid their own responsibility.

Think about it this way. Email platforms have the technical ability to flag suspicious senders, warn users about unverified links. Some of them do this already -but not regularly and often poorly. If Gmail can detect spam well enough to filter most of it automatically, why can't it add a visible warning to emails that contain phrases like "verify immediately" or "limited for a time", "last call".

Similarly - colleges that push students to actively apply for internships online, to respond quickly to opportunities- those same colleges have a responsibility to prepare students for the risks that come with that activity. Not a one hour session in first year. Real, repeated, practical guidance built into the curriculum that help the student and they can be safe from these scam.

So my honest thought is this – yes , individual responsibility exists and matter the most , but it cannot function alone in an environment that is actively designed to make people react quickly and trust appearances. Platforms and institutions can share the load and help the students. So yes platforms or institutions should be held accountable.

A student falls victim to an online scam due to lack of awareness. Should this be viewed as negligence, lack of education, or systemic failure?

It would depend on the case. In what circumstances he gets scammed.

Lets us examine the 3 cases

1) Negligence — Was the Student at Fault?

The negligence argument holds that the student is responsible for their own caution online. If basic warning signs were ignored, that reflects he does not care . So yes this is his fault that despite of knowing he can get scammed he clicked on the link .

Where this leads:

- Basic scam patterns - urgency, too-good-to-be-true offers, requests for personal information -are widely documented
- Want to get a bright future without doing hardwork or using shortcut

2) Lack of education

This case shifts focus from what the student did to what the student was never taught. If they are not taught properly about the scam, not conduct the proper class.

Where this leads:

- Digital literacy is still not a core, compulsory curriculum in most educational systems
- A student cannot apply knowledge they were never given.

3) Systemic Failure

This case question the institutions, platforms and the policymaker

Where this leads:

System	Failure
Tech Platforms	Not able to filtering the scam content, ads, and fraud accounts
Regulatory Bodies	Weak enforcement against cybercrime and digital fraud
Educational Institutions	No mandatory, updated digital safety curriculum.

So by observing three case I thought this can be because lack of education . he did not know about the scammed and got trap into it

Are current preventive measures (passwords, awareness programs, guidelines) sufficient, or do they fail to address deeper behavioral issues?

No, in my opinion current prevention are not enough. And I think most people who work in this space would privately agree. Current measures are basically - use strong passwords, don't click unknown links, scam calls, verify sources, enable two factor authentication. These are not wrong. They're just insufficient on their own.

Because they all assume the user will pause and think before acting. But this is not true . This maybe good in theory but in practical this all fails.

Password can easily hacked. The hacker can easily hack the password within few second. There are many real life incident where password of social media profile are hacked.

Awareness programs are for a short period of time. And after few time people forgets that and get trapped into the scam.

Guidelines are passive. They look good on documents but in real life most people rarely read and almost never revisit. And yes this is true in most case.

The Deeper Behavioral Issues Being Ignored

Behavioral Reality	What Measures Assume	What Actually Happens
Risk feels abstract	Awareness of threat changes behavior	They did not take it seriously until it hits personally
Emotion drives decisions	Rational guidelines guide action	Fear, urgency, and trust on the other come before logic
Humans prioritize	People will accept friction for safety	People find out other ways
Attention	Users stay consistently	But they are not

Section E: Communication and Digital Etiquette

Students often communicate informally due to frequent use of messaging platforms. Short messages and casual language become habitual. When students send emails in formal settings, they may unintentionally use the same style. This results in abrupt or unprofessional communication.

Informal communication is becoming more common, but professionalism remains important. Emails to faculty members, employers, or coordinators require clarity and respect. A poorly written email may create a negative impression, even if the intention is genuine.

Digital communication reflects attitude and seriousness. Proper greetings, context, and polite tone improve credibility. Individuals may be judged based on their communication style because it indicates professionalism.

Therefore, students should consciously adapt their communication depending on context. Maintaining professionalism in digital communication enhances opportunities and relationships.

Section F: Reflection

Before engaging with this case study, my understanding of digital literacy was limited to technical skills. I believed that being digitally literate meant knowing how to use presentation software, collaborative platforms, and social media effectively. I focused more on efficiency and convenience rather than responsibility. However, after analyzing the case study, my perspective has changed significantly. Now I understand that digital literacy also includes awareness of risks, ethical behaviour, professional communication, and responsible decision-making.

One aspect that surprised me was how small digital actions can have long-term consequences. For example, exaggerating skills on an online profile or sending an informal email may seem minor, but these actions can influence opportunities and credibility.

The case made me realize that digital platforms create permanent records. This permanence requires careful thinking before posting or communicating. I also found it uncomfortable to recognize that many students, including myself, sometimes prioritize speed over accuracy and caution.

Reflecting on my own digital habits, I realize that I actively use multiple digital platforms but do not always evaluate their impact. I often rely on quick responses, informal communication, and convenience. While these habits save time, they may reduce professionalism and increase risk. For example, I may not always verify online opportunities carefully or may send short messages without considering tone. This case study encouraged me to rethink about behaviours.

I believe I use digital platforms productively for learning and collaboration, but there is room for improvement. I need to ensure that my online profiles accurately reflect my abilities. I should also focus on improving professionals communication, especially in emails and formal interactions. Additionally, I must develop safer online practices such as verifying links, avoiding sharing sensitive information, and taking time before responding to urgent messages.

If I had to change one aspect of my digital behaviour, I would focus on being more mindful before taking actions online. Instead of responding quickly, I would verify information and consider consequences. This change will help me reduce risks and improve my digital presence.

Overall, this case study has helped me understand that digital literacy is not only about using technology but about using it responsibly and thoughtfully.

